Democracy Dies in Darkness

BRIEFING #71: AFRICAN AMERICANA ON THE NET

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By Bill O'Brian

The Goods: As the Internet grows, it increasingly is fostering networks of like-minded people, whether for practical ends like commerce or for broader goals such as building political communities. An array of Web sites attempts to help African Americans on both levels -- from employment opportunities to culture and literature. The Big Picture: One place to start is EverythingBlack (www.everythingblack.com), a sort of mega-mall home page. It displays 12 broad categories -- from arts and humanities to business, entertainment and travel -- that offer links to hundreds of Web sites, including African American community news outlets all over the country. There are numerous specialized sites, too. Mosaicbooks.com/The Black Literary Showcase (www.mosaicbooks.com), an affiliate of online bookstore Amazon.com, features summaries and recommendations on current black and Hispanic literature. Black Facts Online (www.blackfacts.com) is a fledgling database/search engine that aspires to be "Your Internet Resource of Black History Information." Black Urban Professionals Online (www.buppie.com) provides parenting tips, a resume databank, guidance on personal finance, and professional and social calendars. The Black Collegian Online (www.black-collegian.com) offers career advice and a state-by-state job database. And that's just a smattering. The Last Word: For children, Shelton Jewette, owner of Computers 101, a Northeast Washington computer training center, recommends the Afro-Americ@ Kids Zone (www.afroam.org/children/children.html) -- which includes fables, games, puzzles and brain teasers.